

# Chicken Shawarma

Oil-based marinade · thin-sliced thighs · high-heat chop-and-sear finish

|            |         |          |              |
|------------|---------|----------|--------------|
| YIELD      | ACTIVE  | MARINATE | SPICE RATIO  |
| 900g · 4-6 | ~30 min | 12-24 hr | 2.5% meat wt |

PART 1

SPICE BLEND

Makes ~50g — 22g into one 900g batch

|                    |     |       |                            |    |       |
|--------------------|-----|-------|----------------------------|----|-------|
| Cumin              | 28% | 14 g  | Black pepper               | 7% | 3.5 g |
| Coriander          | 18% | 9 g   | Cinnamon                   | 5% | 2.5 g |
| Paprika sweet      | 15% | 7.5 g | Cardamom green, seeds only | 3% | 1.5 g |
| Turmeric           | 10% | 5 g   | Nutmeg                     | 3% | 1.5 g |
| Allspice signature | 9%  | 4.5 g | Clove                      | 2% | 1 g   |

**Grind everything together in a spice grinder** to a uniform powder — whole spices ground fresh are far more potent than pre-ground (the volatile oils oxidize fast). Grind the whole spices first, then pulse the pre-ground ones (paprika, turmeric) in to homogenize. **Cardamom: green pods, seeds only** — the papery husk is flavorless filler; the 1.5g is seed weight. **Allspice is the signature note** — 9% is conservative, bump to **12-15%** if timid; **go easy on clove**, it dominates fast. Blend keeps **6+ months** sealed.

PART 2

MARINADE

Per 900g boneless skinless thighs

|                                   |           |                         |         |
|-----------------------------------|-----------|-------------------------|---------|
| Chicken thighs boneless, skinless | 900 g     | Lemon juice (5-6%)      | 45-54 g |
| Spice blend (2.5%)                | 22 g      | Garlic minced (3-4%)    | 27-36 g |
| Olive oil (15-20%)                | 135-180 g | Fine sea salt (1.5-2%)  | 14-18 g |
|                                   |           | Onion grated (optional) | 1/2     |

**Why oil-based, not yogurt:** oil carries the fat-soluble spice compounds *into* the meat. Yogurt forms a barrier — it seasons the coating, not the chicken. **Acid held to 5-6%:** thin slices absorb more, and excess acid turns the texture mushy. **Never exceed 48 hr** marinade — the acid degrades the protein.

TEMPERATURE TARGETS

IR gun confirms the surface — don't eyeball it

|                          |               |                  |           |
|--------------------------|---------------|------------------|-----------|
| Pan/griddle surface (IR) | 450-500°F     | Chicken internal | 165-175°F |
| Oil shimmer              | visible waves | Char coverage    | 15-20%    |

# Cook & Finish

PART 3

METHOD

Active ~30 min — serve immediately, no rest

- 1

**Slice:** trim fat, slice thighs horizontally to ¼" (6mm). Thin = complete flavor penetration — the whole reason the inside isn't bland.
- 2

**Build:** whisk oil, lemon, garlic, salt, and spices until **deeply tinted**. Taste — it should read aggressive; the meat tames it.
- 3

**Marinate:** coat every piece, bag or container, refrigerate **12–24 hr** (24 = full development). **Max 48 hr.**
- 4

**Temper:** pull from fridge **30 min early**. Heat **cast iron / flat-top griddle** until screaming hot — **IR-confirm 450–500°F**.
- 5

**Sear: single-layer batches**, 2–3 min/side for char. Let the surface recover between batches — **crowding = steam**, no char. Target 15–20% surface char.
- 6

**Chop:** all pieces back on the hot surface, chop with two spatulas, let sit **30–60 sec**, toss. Builds crispy edges.
- 7

**Serve: immediately, no rest** — crispy edges degrade fast. Pull at **165–175°F**. Taste before wrapping; it should eat great plain.

**Chop-and-sear replicates the spit:** a vertical shawarma spit does two things — bastes in rendered fat and chars on high heat. Thin slice + oil marinade + screaming-hot iron + the chop step reproduces both at home. **Flat-top advantage:** more surface = bigger single-layer batches without crowding, which is the #1 cause of no char.

TROUBLESHOOTING

| PROBLEM       | CAUSE                               | FIX                                   |
|---------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Bland inside  | Slices too thick or under-marinated | Slice ¼" (6mm); full 24 hr marinade   |
| No char       | Surface too cool or overcrowded     | Smaller batches; recover to 450–500°F |
| Dry meat      | Overcooked or under-oiled marinade  | Check 165–175°F; use 15–20% oil       |
| Muted spice   | Under-spiced                        | Scale to 3% meat wt; raise allspice   |
| Mushy texture | Over 48 hr marinade or excess acid  | Keep under 48 hr; hold lemon at 5–6%  |

SCALING

Hold the ratios — spice 2.5%, oil 15–20%, lemon 5–6%

1 LB (~450G)

|             |      |
|-------------|------|
| Spice blend | 11 g |
| Olive oil   | 70 g |
| Lemon juice | 25 g |
| Garlic      | 15 g |
| Salt        | 7 g  |

3 LB (~1,360G)

|             |       |
|-------------|-------|
| Spice blend | 34 g  |
| Olive oil   | 200 g |
| Lemon juice | 70 g  |
| Garlic      | 45 g  |
| Salt        | 20 g  |